

2.1 Formats/Codecs

The very first thing we come across when dealing with digital audio (or even video) are formats and codecs. The open source community, as one might expect, has its own fair share of lossless and lossy audio codecs and formats for audio. And frankly speaking, they're pretty good alternatives to the more popular and closed source MP3 and WMA formats.

2.1.1 Ogg Vorbis

www.vorbis.com

Perhaps the most popular open source audio container, Ogg Vorbis files have the .ogg extension. Most media players today can play this format, and it being open source, even if your media player does not natively support this format, you can still download the requisite codecs and play .ogg files.

Unlike other patented formats such as MP3 or AAC, Ogg Vorbis is completely free. First we should tell you that Ogg is a container format, such as MP3 or AAC, and was developed by Xiph.org. Vorbis is the compression algorithm, and Xiph.org is the open source community/project that developed and now maintains the Ogg Vorbis format.

Xiph is short for Xiphophorus helleri, a tiny aquarium fish that is also known as a swordtail. There's no particular connection to the fish, except that the founder liked the name. The name was shortened to Xiph (pronounced *zif*).

The Ogg project was originally called "Squish," as in "a bug hit my windscreen and was *squished*." Until Xiph was informed that a mail transport company owned the trademark. At the time, a network game called *Netrek* was popular, and Xiph borrowed the name for a tactical manoeuvre—Og!

From an archived Internet page: "In the multi-player space combat game *Netrek*, to execute kamikaze attacks against